

Project Retrospective #4

Throughout this semester, working on the EVA Smart Systems website project has taught me many things about web development, teamwork, and project management. However, the single most impactful lesson I have taken away from this experience is the critical importance of consistent, proactive communication with clients. Our team struggled with this throughout the project, and the consequences were significant. Looking back, I can clearly see how a lack of timely and structured communication led to delayed feedback, unclear requirements, and ultimately a great deal of rework that could have been avoided.

One of the most prominent issues we faced was delayed feedback from our client, Troy. This was not because Troy was unresponsive or difficult to work with. Rather, it was because our team did not establish a regular cadence of check-ins or create clear opportunities for her to review our progress early and often. For example, our team spent considerable time building the site as a Vite and React application deployed on Vercel, only to learn later that Troy's strong preference was to use Squarespace as the primary platform. She had been paying for Squarespace already and was concerned about duplicate costs. Had we confirmed the platform strategy earlier in the project, we would not have invested so heavily in architecture that may not survive the transition. Instead, the feedback arrived after significant development work had already been completed, and the team was left trying to reconcile two different directions.

A similar pattern emerged with the design and visual identity of the site. Troy eventually sent us a reference document containing her preferred colors, fonts, copy, and image assignments for each page. This document was extremely helpful, but it arrived well into the development cycle. By that point, our team had already made design decisions that did not align with her vision. For instance, her document specified exact color tokens like a navy blue for headings and a royal blue for buttons, along with specific font pairings and photo assignments for each page. She was particularly frustrated about duplicate photos appearing across pages, something we could have caught early if we had shared mockups or wireframes

with her before writing code. The rework needed to align the existing site with her design tokens was substantial and could have been minimized with earlier visual check-ins.

The second major issue was unclear requirements, which compounded the delayed feedback problem. A clear example of this was the Connect page, which serves as the main contact and signup form for the site. Troy had previously approved several specific features for this page during earlier meetings, including a Title field between the Name and Company fields, a checkbox for the CEO Visionary Waitlist tied to the EVOLVE Retreat, and a confidentiality disclaimer at the bottom of the form. However, when she later sent her reference code for the Connect page, those approved fields were missing from her HTML. Because our team did not have a shared requirements document that tracked what had been agreed upon in meetings, there was a risk of those features being dropped entirely. Without clear documentation and communication loops, approved decisions can quietly disappear, and no one notices until much later.

This experience has made a lasting impact on how I think about project work. In a classroom setting, it is easy to assume that the requirements are fixed and written down in a project brief. In a real client engagement, requirements evolve through conversations, emails, and meetings, and it is the team's responsibility to capture, confirm, and communicate those decisions back to the client regularly. I have learned that communication is not just a soft skill or a nice-to-have. It is a core project management discipline that directly affects the quality and efficiency of the technical work. Going forward, I plan to advocate for regular client demos, shared requirement trackers, and written meeting summaries in any team project I participate in. The cost of silence is always rework, and rework is always more expensive than a quick check-in.